

The Shell

There is a box under the lip of the stage, hooded over like a half-buried ear, and the trade calls it the shell. It is reached from under the stage by a short stair. Eleven steps. He counted them once, in the beginning, and then had them.

He went down before the house opened and came up after it emptied. Between the two, above him, the play went on the way the day goes on above a cellar: entirely, and without him, unless.

His work was silence. Not the keeping of it; the ending of it. There are two silences on a stage. One is the play breathing — written, counted, safe. The other is a line failing to arrive. The first was none of his business. The second was all the business he had. Telling them apart was not a skill that could be shown.

The line, when it failed, had to be put back quietly — under the house's hearing, into the actor's, inside the half-second before the failure showed. Done well, the work was attributed to memory. Done less well, it was attributed to him. On his best nights he did not occur.

He had the repertory whole. Forty plays; fifty, with the farces nobody would admit to. Every part, including the ones no one had ever forgotten: the corpse's, the dog's. He had more theater in him unsaid than the company had said in its history, and none of it was his, and all of it was ready.

He had come to the shell the way the shell is always come to: down. At nineteen he had been the messenger in *The Winter Gate*, third act, one line. The line did not arrive. He stood in the light while the second silence grew personal, and a voice from under the stage put the line back into him, quietly, too late. He finished the season above. He was not asked to stay there. He asked to go down.

The line was: *No one is coming tonight.*

It never left him again. Nightly, at nineteen, in the light, it does not arrive; nightly it arrives now, from below, in time. Not a cure; a schedule.

In the twelfth year he brought down a cushion. He was not proud of it.

In the book he kept marks for the lines that failed often, and marks for the lines that failed rarely, and for the lines that had never failed he kept a mark also, which was no mark. The book itself he kept open out of ceremony; the book was in him.

There had been the winter in Kamen Brod, when the ford closed behind the

company, and the town, by the second pass through the repertory, prompted from the floor — in chorus, gently, with corrections. He sat those evenings in the shell with his hands in his sleeves, replaced by a public. He did not hold it against them. He held it.

The one who played the queens never dried. Forty years, upward of eleven thousand cues by his private count, and never once. He considered this the finest fact he had about anybody. She knew the shell existed the way a house with water knows the well; she had never lowered the bucket.

Then one evening, late in her queens, she stopped. Mid-scene, on no cue, in a place where nothing was owed. He went through the play in one breath. The play was whole. Nothing was missing. It was neither of the two silences. She stood in it, looking at nothing, in the direction of the shell.

He gave her the next line. It was not missing. He gave it anyway.

She took it, and went on, and finished her queens that year, and it was never spoken of, there being — he checked — no words in the repertory for a silence with nothing missing.

The queens went to a girl from the capital, who was good, and dried.

The house thinned. The repertory narrowed from the banks: the crowd scenes went first, then the second leads, then the plays that wanted weather. Toward the end the seasons were one old actor in one chair, in a play about an old actor in a chair. The old man dried on everything, and the play passed through the shell entire, line by line, whisper first, voice after. Both performances were given nightly, and only one was reviewed.

Then the license was not renewed. What could be carried was carried off. The shell could not be carried. It is a hole.

He goes down still. A way into an empty building is not hard to keep. At the hour when the house would open he is in the shell. Eleven steps; he has them still. Above him the dark sits complete. Nothing is missing. It is the third silence, and it is his cue.

He leans to the lip and gives the line, quietly, in time, to the whole of the dark at once.

No one is coming tonight.